

TITLE: TO BE DECIDED

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ABSTRACT. In recent papers [1] [2], topological data analysis has proven to be a very effective method for analyzing spatiotemporal patterns in the spread of drug use and disease. We extend these results to the state of Virginia by using a combination of classic tools from statistics and recent tools from topological data analysis (or TDA) by developing a hybrid method for analyzing the evolution of drug overdose data for the state of Virginia. By using the Kepler mapper algorithm along with a multifaceted lens function, combining an isolation forest along with the l_2 norm and a K-Means clustering algorithm we analyze and identify the evolution of patterns and hotspots in the spatiotemporal distribution of the Virginia drug overdose data.

1. DATA SOURCES

To account for variation in county population size across the Commonwealth of Virginia, we incorporated county-level population estimates for the year 2025 obtained from the Virginia Population Estimates Project. These estimates were sourced from the Weldon Cooper Center for Public Service and compiled in the dataset `virginia-counties-by-population-(2025).csv`. The dataset provides population estimates for all Virginia counties and independent cities.

Opioid overdose outcome data were obtained from the Virginia Department of Health (VDH) through multiple publicly available datasets. Annual county-level overdose mortality data for the years 2018–2023 were sourced from the dataset `VDHPUDOverdoseDeathsByYearAndGeographyLoc` which includes geographic identifiers and associated latitude and longitude coordinates. More recent overdose mortality data for 2024 and 2025 were obtained from `vdh-pud-overdose-deaths-by-year-` extending the temporal scope of the analysis.

Additional supporting datasets published by the Commonwealth of Virginia were used to contextualize overdose mortality trends. These include monthly counts of deaths by select causes (2014–2019), emergency department visits related to opioid overdose by health region and month, overdose deaths reported by year and quarter, arrest data with geographic identifiers, and indicators from the Virginia Drug Overdose Needs Assessment Tool. All datasets were obtained from the Virginia Department of Health and the Commonwealth of Virginia open data portal.

2. DATA PREPROCESSING AND NORMALIZATION

Raw opioid outcome measures were normalized using county-level population estimates to mitigate bias introduced by population size. For each county i and year t , let $O_{i,t}$ denote the observed opioid-related outcome and let $P_{i,t}$ denote the corresponding population estimate. Population-normalized rates were computed according to

Date: January 16, 2026.

2010 *Mathematics Subject Classification.* Primary: 92E15, 18G35, 57M15, 80A50 Secondary: 05C05, 05C21, 05E45, 82C31.

$$(1) \quad R_{i,t} = \frac{O_{i,t}}{P_{i,t}} \times 10,000,$$

where $R_{i,t}$ represents the outcome rate per 10,000 residents. This normalization step ensures that downstream analyses reflect relative prevalence rather than absolute counts.

The overdose datasets span multiple temporal resolutions, including monthly, quarterly, and annual reporting intervals. To ensure consistency across datasets, monthly and quarterly measures were aggregated to annual summaries when integrated with county-level population data. Counties with missing observations for specific years were retained when possible to preserve spatial continuity.

All normalized variables were subsequently scaled prior to topological analysis to ensure comparability across dimensions and to prevent any single variable from dominating the distance metric.

3. TOPOLOGICAL DATA ANALYSIS FRAMEWORK

Each county-year observation was represented as a point in a multidimensional feature space consisting of population-normalized overdose mortality rates, selected public health indicators, and geographic coordinates. Latitude and longitude information enabled counties to be embedded directly in a two-dimensional spatial framework, allowing geographic proximity to influence the underlying metric structure.

Distance between observations was computed using the standardized feature vectors, and the resulting metric space served as input for topological data analysis. Population normalization plays a critical role in the topological representation, as persistent homological features are sensitive to scale and distance relationships. By using per-capita opioid rates, the resulting topological structures capture similarities in epidemic severity rather than artifacts driven by county population size.

Persistent homology was applied to this metric space to identify connected components, cycles, and higher-dimensional features that characterize structural patterns in the opioid epidemic across Virginia. Incorporating both spatial and temporal information enables identification of regional clustering, transitional zones, and persistent hotspots that may not be apparent through traditional statistical or regression-based approaches.

DATA AVAILABILITY

Population estimates were obtained from the Weldon Cooper Center for Public Service at the University of Virginia and are publicly available at <https://www.coopercenter.org/virginia-population-estimates>. Opioid overdose mortality and related public health datasets were obtained from the Virginia Department of Health and the Commonwealth of Virginia open data portal, including county-level overdose deaths by year and geography, emergency department visit data, arrest data, and indicators from the Virginia Drug Overdose Needs Assessment Tool.

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4. INTRODUCTION

REFERENCES

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